

Session 8: Reconciled Through Covenant

Key Takeaways

- Yitskhaq's story in Genesis 26 is the whole biblical narrative in miniature, and it ends with this scene of reconciliation through covenant.
- The biblical authors use garden of Eden imagery to talk about the reconciliation of rival families, linking this theme to God's ultimate purpose of bringing blessing to all people through his chosen one.

Yitskhaq and Abimelech Make a Covenant of Peace

26 Now, Avimelek **came to him** from Gerar,
and **his companion** Ahuzzath,
and Phicol the commander of his army.

27 And Yitskhaq said to them,
"Why have **you come to me**,
since **you hate me**,
and **you sent me away from you**?"

28 And they said,
"We can surely see that **Yahweh is with you**,
and we say,
'Let there now be an **oath-curse** between us,
between you and us,
and let us make a **covenant** with you,
29 that you will do no **bad** to us,
just as we have not touched you
and we have done to you nothing but **good**
and we will send you away in peace.
You are now the one **blessed by Yahweh.**"

30 And he made them a feast,
and they ate and drank.

31 And arose early in the morning,
and they **swore oaths**, **each to his brother**
and Yitskhaq sent them away

and they went from him in peace .

³² And it came about on the same day,
that Yitskhaq's servants came,
and they told him about the well which they had dug
and they said to him, " We have found water ."
³³ And he called it " Oath ";
therefore the name of the city is " Well of Oath " to this day.

Genesis 26:26-33. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Tribal Rivalry Reconciled Through Covenant

Just like after the flood, when God reconciled with violent humans through a covenant, here potentially violent humans reconcile through covenant.

Note: The seemingly random mention of "Phicol, commander of the army" ([Gen. 26:26](#)) is a subtle recall of the "sons of *elohim*" and their violent warrior offspring, the Nephilim from [Genesis 6:1-4](#). The sons of *elohim* can also be called "the army of the skies" (a.k.a. "the host of heaven," see [1 Kgs. 22:19](#) and [Job 1:6-8](#)). Here in the Yitskhaq story, the presence of Phicol makes us think of the mutant warriors of [Genesis 6:4](#), but only to twist our expectation. Now, the warriors come to make peace with God's chosen one!

Just as Abimelech made peace with Abraham (about a disputed well!) through a covenant in [Genesis 21:21-34](#), so now Abimelech makes a similar pact with Abraham's son about disputed wells.

This story becomes a narrative image of how Yahweh wants to spread the Eden blessing out to the nations through his chosen family. It requires courageous honesty in his chosen one (Yitskhaq, who fails at first), and it requires an openness among the nations to receive God's chosen one (Abimelech, who also fails at first). But both of these failures are reversed by the end of [Genesis 26](#), and the nations reconcile and live in peace through the covenant at the Well of Seven!

The point: When God's chosen one simply trusts the promise, they discover God's life-giving blessing even in the midst of death and desert. When the nations acknowledge God's chosen one, they find themselves included in the Eden blessing through the covenant!

Concluding Reflections on the Stories of Yitskhaq and Abraham

As we conclude the story of Yitskhaq, we see how every part of his story has been mapped onto the story of his father Abraham.

Avraham entered Canaan in a time of famine.	Yitskhaq comes of age in Canaan in a time of famine.
Avraham put God's promise and his wife at risk because of fear (the Pharaoh and Avimelek debacles).	Yitskhaq puts God's promise and his wife at risk because of fear (the Avimelek debacle).
Avraham became wealthy because of God's blessing, and this caused rivalry and conflict with the non-chosen (Avraham and Lot).	Yitskhaq became wealthy because of God's blessing, and this caused rivalry and conflict with the non-chosen.
This conflict with the nations, about wells, was only resolved through a covenant.	This conflict with the nations, about wells, was only resolved through a covenant.
<i>Reflections on the Stories of Yitskhaq and Avraham.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).	

This is a very clear narrative strategy that shows how the son's life is a replay and twist on the story of the father's life. Which makes us wonder about Yitskhaq's sons. Will they also replay the story of their father's failures and successes?

- Abraham had conflict with Lot, Pharaoh, and Abimelech.
- Yitskhaq has conflict with Abimelech that is resolved through covenant.
- Yaaqov will have conflict with Esau.
- Yaaqov and his descendants will also have a conflict with Pharaoh.

Reflection Question

How does Yitskhaq's story tell the whole biblical narrative in miniature?